concern about my serve because it was difficult to inject any genuine power when I was relatively short for my age. At one point, I was coached to serve like Boris Becker, throwing the ball high and leaping into the air as I served. I suppose, if I had been able to serve like the great German, I would have continued to develop and might have played at Wimbledon, Flushing Meadows and the rest.

Several of my rivals on the junior circuit did turn professional.

Izak van der Merwe was an outstanding player from Stellenbosch who grew up to win three professional titles, compete at Wimbledon and represent South Africa in the Davis Cup. Kevin Anderson is a couple of years younger than me, though somewhat taller at 6' 8", and we had some close matches all those years ago. I have enjoyed following his career, through the quarterfinals at the 2015 US Open and into the world's top ten.

There were others, giants in my memory.

Christopher Westerhof, a left-hander from Durban, was my most difficult opponent. We seemed to play each other in semifinals and finals all over the country. The matches were invariably tight and there were many tie-breakers but, somehow, he was generally able to win the points that mattered. He had the edge.

Michael Shapiro was another fine player. I remember playing a semifinal against him at Groenkloof in Pretoria when he was 14 years old and I was a year younger, and everything went my way. Every serve, every passing shot and every volley came off the racket perfectly and the tennis coach from Waterkloof High School approached my parents and offered me a bursary to attend his school. It was exciting to be scouted and I recall thinking that maybe I could turn pro and play at Wimbledon, but one swallow doesn't make a summer.

Danie van der Walt, from Witbank, was another top performer, and I was fortunate to have him on my side of the net when we were ranked as the No. 1 Under-14 doubles pair in the country.

I continued to play tennis when I moved to Afrikaanse Hoër Seunskool,